ADVENTIST UNIVERSITY OF CENTRAL AFRICA
FACULTY OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION
DEPARTMENT OF ACCOUNTING

ESTABLISHING A RENTING HOUSE AT REMERA CENTER: A MARKET SURVEY

By
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A research project submitted to the Department of Accounting in the Faculty of Business Administration

In partial fulfilment of the requirements of the course of Study and Research Methods for the award of the Bachelor of Arts in Business Administration with Honours in Accounting

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CHAPTER 1
INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Rwanda has experienced rapid urbanisation over the past decade, and the City of Kigali has been at the centre of this transformation. The urban population of Kigali rose from about 1.1 million people in 2017 to over 1.7 million people in 2022, and the city continues to record an annual housing gap estimated at around 31,000 units (Amaltas Properties, 2025). This growing gap between housing supply and housing need has placed considerable pressure on the rental housing sub-sector, which has become the dominant form of tenure for a large share of Kigali's residents.

A study commissioned by the International Growth Centre projected that close to 373,000 additional households would require accommodation in Kigali between 2017 and 2032, representing an annual demand of between 18,000 and 32,000 new households, in addition to an existing housing backlog of about 137,000 units recorded in 2017 (Bower, Murray & Buckley, 2019). National household survey data collected before this period already indicated that renters made up more than 40 percent of Kigali's population, a share that has almost certainly increased given the continuing pace of rural-urban migration (National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, as cited in the Kigali Housing Study, 2015).

Remera, one of the fifteen sectors of Gasabo District and host to the district headquarters, recorded a population of 38,648 residents according to the Fifth Rwanda Population and Housing Census of 2022. Remera center is widely recognised as one of the busiest commercial and residential nodes within Kigali because of its central location, its proximity to the Kigali Convention Centre, Amahoro Stadium and BK Arena, and its dense network of shops, offices and public transport routes (Malunda, Hlambelo & associates, 2020). These characteristics make the area attractive for both residential and small-scale commercial rental investment, and they explain why prospective investors, including students of business administration, continue to view Remera center as a promising location for a renting house business.

Despite this apparent opportunity, the residential rental sub-sector in Rwanda generally remains poorly documented and largely informal, so that many small investors rely on assumption, personal observation, or word of mouth rather than verified market information when deciding to establish a renting house business (Access to Finance Rwanda, 2021). It is against this background that the present study was undertaken, with the aim of conducting a focused market survey on establishing a renting house business at Remera center, so as to generate evidence-based information on tenant demand, pricing expectations, preferred facilities, and the challenges facing landlords in that specific market.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Although demand for rental accommodation in Kigali continues to grow, many small and medium investors enter the renting house business without adequate information about the specific needs, preferences and paying capacity of potential tenants in their target location. Web-based evidence collected on rent and sale prices across Rwanda shows wide variation in pricing that is not always matched to the quality or location of the unit on offer (Access to Finance Rwanda, 2022), while commentary on the sector notes that some rental properties remain vacant for long periods because they are mismatched with tenant expectations in terms of price, size or facilities, while other investors under-price their units and fail to recover the capital invested in construction (House in Rwanda, 2025).

At Remera center specifically, the rapid growth in commercial activity and population inflow suggests a potentially strong rental market. However, no localised study appears to have been carried out to verify the actual level of demand, the type of housing units and facilities preferred by potential tenants, the amount tenants are willing and able to pay, and the challenges currently faced by landlords operating in this specific area. In the absence of such information, an investor intending to establish a renting house business at Remera center risks basing important decisions on assumption rather than evidence, a situation that may lead to under-utilised units, mismatched pricing, and eventual financial loss. This study therefore sets out to address this problem by conducting a market survey on establishing a renting house business at Remera center.

1.3 Research Objectives of the Study

1.3.1 General Objective

The general objective of this study is to conduct a market survey on establishing a renting house business at Remera center, in order to assess its viability and inform sound investment decision-making.

1.3.2 Specific Objectives

1. To assess the level of demand for rental housing at Remera center.

2. To determine the amount that potential tenants are willing and able to pay for rental housing units at Remera center.

3. To identify the type of housing units and facilities preferred by potential tenants at Remera center.

4. To examine the challenges faced by existing landlords and potential investors in the renting house business at Remera center.

1.4 Research Questions

1. What is the level of demand for rental housing at Remera center?

2. How much are potential tenants willing and able to pay for rental housing units at Remera center?

3. What types of housing units and facilities are preferred by potential tenants at Remera center?

4. What challenges do existing landlords and potential investors face in the renting house business at Remera center?

1.5 Hypothesis

H0: There is no significant relationship between the location and facilities of a rental house and tenants' willingness to pay for it at Remera center.

H1: There is a significant relationship between the location and facilities of a rental house and tenants' willingness to pay for it at Remera center.

1.6 Justification of the Study

A number of studies have already examined the housing market in Kigali, though mostly at a broad, city-wide level. The International Growth Centre commissioned a housing needs assessment that projected housing demand and affordability across the entire city (Bower, Murray & Buckley, 2019), while the Institute of Policy Analysis and Research Rwanda examined both the formal and informal housing markets, focusing on issues of supply, housing quality and tenure choice across Kigali as a whole. Access to Finance Rwanda similarly conducted a demand-side analysis of affordable housing together with a web-scraping study of rent and sale prices drawn from online property listings across the country (Access to Finance Rwanda, 2021, 2022). Malunda and associates (2020) went further to study the commercial real estate market across several sectors of Kigali, Remera included, but their focus was strictly on commercial buildings rather than residential renting houses.

While these studies provide useful city-wide and sector-wide statistics, none of them provides a focused, ground-level market survey of the residential renting house business specifically within Remera center, and none captures the direct opinions, preferences and willingness to pay of individual potential tenants in that particular market. This study contributes to existing knowledge by narrowing the unit of analysis to Remera center and by collecting primary data directly from potential tenants and existing landlords in that area. In this way, it provides localised, tenant-informed evidence that can directly guide an investor's decision on whether, and how, to establish a renting house business at Remera center, something that the broader city-wide studies reviewed above were not designed to do.

1.7 Significance of the Study

To the investor: the findings of this study will provide the researcher, and any other person intending to invest at Remera center, with evidence-based information on demand, pricing and preferred facilities, which will guide the decision on whether and how to establish a renting house business in the area.

To the local authorities: the study will provide local leaders and urban planners in Gasabo District with additional insight into the housing needs and challenges of residents around Remera center, which may support planning and regulation of the rental housing sub-sector.

To the academic community: the study will add to the relatively small body of localised literature on Rwanda's rental housing market and will serve as a reference for other students and researchers undertaking similar market survey studies in other locations.

To the researcher: the study enables the researcher to fulfil the academic requirements of the course of Study and Research Methods and to develop practical research, analytical and report-writing skills required for the accounting profession.

1.8 Scope and Delimitation of the Study

Geographical scope: the study is confined to Remera center, in Remera Sector, Gasabo District, City of Kigali.

Content scope: the study is limited to the market survey aspects of establishing a renting house business, namely the level of demand, tenants' willingness to pay, preferred housing types and facilities, and the challenges facing landlords and investors. It does not cover architectural design, construction engineering, or detailed financial modelling of the business.

Time scope: the study was conducted in the year 2026 and reflects rental housing market conditions prevailing at Remera center at that time.

Respondent scope: the study targets potential tenants (including students, employees and small business operators) and existing landlords or property agents operating around Remera center.

CHAPTER 2
LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Conceptual Review

This section defines the key terms and concepts used throughout the study.

Renting house: a residential or mixed-use building, or a unit within it, that is constructed or acquired by an owner (landlord) for the purpose of letting it out to another person (tenant) in exchange for periodic payment, usually referred to as rent.

Market survey: a systematic process of gathering, recording and analysing information about a target market, including the needs, preferences and buying (or renting) behaviour of potential customers, with a view to informing a business decision.

Demand: the quantity of a good or service, in this case rental housing units, that potential tenants are willing and able to rent at a given price over a specific period of time.

Rental market: the segment of the housing market in which dwelling units are let out to tenants rather than sold, and in which rental prices are determined by the interaction of tenant demand and landlord supply.

Feasibility: the extent to which a proposed business idea, such as establishing a renting house, is practically achievable and likely to be profitable given the available market, resources and constraints.

Tenant: an individual or household that occupies a rented housing unit under an agreement with the landlord, in return for payment of rent.

Landlord: the owner of a rental property who lets it out to tenants and is responsible for its maintenance and management.

2.2 Theory Related to the Study

This study is guided by two complementary theories. The first is the Bid-Rent Theory, originally advanced by Alonso (1964), which explains how households and businesses are willing to pay more for land and buildings that are closer to a central business district or to major amenities, and progressively less as distance from that centre increases, because proximity reduces transport time and cost and increases access to services. This theory is directly relevant to the present study because Remera center's central location within Gasabo District, and its proximity to major facilities such as the Kigali Convention Centre and

Amahoro Stadium, is expected to influence how much potential tenants are willing to pay for a rental unit located there compared with more peripheral areas.

The second is the basic economic theory of Demand and Supply, which holds that the price of a good or service, in this case a rental housing unit, is determined by the interaction between the quantity that tenants are willing and able to rent (demand) and the quantity of units that landlords are willing to offer (supply) at a given price. When demand for rental housing at Remera center exceeds the available supply, rental prices tend to rise, and investors who correctly anticipate this imbalance stand to benefit; when supply exceeds demand, units remain vacant and prices tend to fall. This theory underpins the study's attempt to measure the current balance between tenant demand and available rental units at Remera center.

2.3 Empirical Review

Bower, Murray and Buckley (2019), in a report prepared for the International Growth Centre, examined housing need in Kigali City as a whole. Their study estimated that Kigali would require accommodation for about 373,000 additional households between 2017 and 2032, and it further estimated the purchasing power of both tenant households and mortgage-holding households across different income groups. Although the study provides valuable city-wide projections of housing demand, it does not disaggregate its findings to the level of individual commercial centres such as Remera, and it relies mainly on secondary demographic and income data rather than direct interviews with potential tenants in a specific micro-location.

The Institute of Policy Analysis and Research Rwanda undertook a housing market study for Kigali City that examined both the formal and informal segments of the market, including current housing supply, housing composition and quality, the housing backlog, use of housing finance, and the determinants of the choice between renting and owning a home. This study offers useful insight into the general drivers of tenure choice in Kigali, but again its scope is city-wide rather than focused on the specific dynamics of a single commercial center such as Remera.

Malunda and associates (2020), writing for the International Growth Centre, studied the commercial real estate market in the City of Kigali and explicitly included Remera among the commercial nodes surveyed, alongside areas such as Nyarugenge, Kacyiru, Kimironko and Nyamirambo. Their survey collected data on occupancy rates, rent levels and tenant demand for commercial buildings. While this confirms that Remera is recognised as an active real estate node, the study's focus is limited to commercial (business) premises and does not examine the residential renting house segment that is the subject of the present study.

Access to Finance Rwanda (2021) conducted a demand-side analysis of affordable housing in Rwanda and observed that the country's residential rental sector remains critical but poorly documented, operating largely outside the reach of formal policy and finance. In a companion study, Access to Finance Rwanda (2022) used a web-scraping technique to collect and analyse rent and sale prices advertised on Rwandan property websites. These studies confirm that rental pricing data exists but is scattered and drawn mainly from online advertisements rather than from direct engagement with tenants and landlords on the ground, which is the gap that the present study addresses through a primary survey at Remera center.

More recent commentary on Kigali's real estate sector notes that the city continues to record one of the highest rental yields in Sub-Saharan Africa, driven partly by a housing deficit estimated at close to 17,000 affordable units per year and by a comparatively high rate of population growth (House in Rwanda, 2025). Similarly, industry commentary observes that Kigali's housing gap is expected to widen considerably over the next decade as the country pursues its middle-income aspirations (Amaltas Properties, 2025). These sources reinforce the general attractiveness of the Kigali rental market, but, like the studies discussed above, they do not provide site-specific evidence for a location such as Remera center.

2.4 Literature Gap

The empirical review above shows that, while considerable research exists on Kigali's housing market at the city-wide or district-wide level, the reviewed studies share three notable limitations. First, most of them analyse housing demand and pricing in aggregate terms, without disaggregating findings to the level of a specific commercial center such as Remera. Second, several of the studies rely heavily on secondary data, census statistics, or web-scraped advertisements, rather than on primary data collected directly from potential tenants and landlords in a defined micro-market. Third, none of the reviewed studies specifically investigates the challenges facing landlords who already operate, or intend to operate, a renting house business at Remera center, nor do they examine tenants' specific facility preferences (such as security, water supply, parking, or proximity to transport) in that particular location.

The present study addresses these gaps by conducting a focused, primary-data market survey at Remera center, targeting both potential tenants and existing landlords, so as to generate localised evidence on demand, willingness to pay, preferred facilities and operational challenges that can directly inform an investment decision in that specific market.

2.5 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework below illustrates the relationship between the independent variables identified from the literature review and the dependent variable of this study, namely tenant demand for, and willingness to invest in, a renting house at Remera center.

INDEPENDENT VARIABLES		DEPENDENT VARIABLE
• Location and proximity to amenities • Rental price level • Housing facilities and quality • Security and safety of the area	→	Tenant demand and willingness to invest in a renting house business at Remera center

As shown above, the framework assumes that a rental house's location and proximity to amenities, its rental price level, the quality of facilities it offers, and the security of the surrounding area jointly influence the level of tenant demand and, ultimately, an investor's willingness to establish and sustain a renting house business at Remera center. A change in any one independent variable, for example an improvement in security or the addition of a reliable water supply, is expected to positively affect tenant demand, while an unreasonably high rental price relative to facilities offered is expected to reduce it. This framework guided the design of the research instruments used to collect data for this study.

CHAPTER 3
RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

This study adopted a descriptive research design with a cross-sectional survey approach. A descriptive design was considered appropriate because the study seeks to describe the current level of demand, pricing expectations, facility preferences and challenges associated with establishing a renting house business at Remera center, rather than to manipulate any variable. A mixed-methods approach was used, combining quantitative data collected through a structured questionnaire with qualitative data collected through interviews with a small number of key informants, so as to obtain both measurable market indicators and a deeper understanding of the challenges landlords face. The cross-sectional nature of the design means that data was collected from respondents at a single point in time during the 2026 field work period, which is sufficient for a market assessment of this nature.

3.2 Population and Sampling

3.2.1 Target Population

The target population of this study comprises two groups of beneficiaries relevant to the renting house business at Remera center. The first and primary group is made up of potential tenants residing, working, studying or trading around Remera center, including employees of nearby offices, small business operators, and students, who represent the potential customers of a renting house business. The second, smaller group is made up of existing landlords and property agents already operating rental houses in the area, who provide insight into current market challenges. Based on the Fifth Rwanda Population and Housing Census (2022), Remera Sector had a resident population of 38,648 people. This figure was adopted as the sampling frame (N) for the potential-tenant population of this study, since Remera center forms the commercial and residential core of the sector.

3.2.2 Sample Size Determination

The sample size for potential tenants was determined using Slovin's Formula, given as:

$$n = N / (1 + N e^2)$$

Where n is the required sample size, N is the target population, and e is the margin of error, set at 5% (0.05) for this study, which is the conventional level used for social and business research.

Applying the formula:

$$n = 38{,}648 / (1 + 38{,}648 \times 0.05^2)$$
$$n = 38{,}648 / (1 + 96.62) = 38{,}648 / 97.62$$
$$\mathbf{n \approx 396 \text{ respondents}}$$

Therefore, a sample of approximately 396 potential tenants was targeted for the questionnaire survey. In addition, 10 existing landlords or property agents operating around Remera center were purposively selected for key informant interviews, bringing the total planned sample to 406 respondents.

3.2.3 Sampling Technique

A combination of stratified random sampling and purposive sampling was used. For the potential-tenant population, the sample was first stratified into three strata reflecting the main categories of people found around Remera center, namely employees/salaried workers, small business operators/traders, and students. Respondents were then selected from each stratum using simple random sampling, which gives every member of a stratum an equal chance of being selected and helps ensure that the final sample proportionately reflects the different categories of potential tenants found in the area. Purposive sampling was used to select the 10 landlords and property agents interviewed, since these key informants needed to be individuals with direct, verifiable experience of managing rental property at Remera center, a characteristic that random selection could not guarantee.

3.3 Design of the Research Instrument

Two main instruments were designed for data collection. The first is a structured questionnaire, administered to the sample of potential tenants. The questionnaire combines closed-ended questions, including dichotomous (yes/no) and multiple-choice items, with a small number of five-point Likert-scale items used to measure attitudes toward pricing and facility preferences, and it also includes a few open-ended questions to allow respondents to express views not captured by the fixed options. The questionnaire is organised into sections covering respondent background information, current housing situation, demand for rental housing, willingness to pay, preferred facilities, and general comments.

The second instrument is an interview guide, used for the key informant interviews with landlords and property agents. The interview guide is semi-structured, consisting of open-ended questions that allow the researcher to probe further on issues such as occupancy rates, pricing strategies, tenant turnover, and the operational challenges landlords face, while still keeping the discussion focused on the study's objectives. Both instruments were reviewed for clarity and content validity before use, and the questionnaire was pre-tested on a small number of respondents outside the main sample to identify and correct any ambiguous questions.

3.4 Data Collection Methods

Primary data was collected using the questionnaire and the interview guide described above. The questionnaire was administered face-to-face by the researcher and, where necessary, with the help of trained research assistants, to potential tenants found at Remera center during the agreed field work period. Face-to-face administration was preferred because it allows the researcher to clarify questions on the spot and generally achieves a higher response rate than self-administered or online questionnaires in this context. The key informant interviews with landlords and property agents were conducted individually, at times and locations convenient to the respondents, and notes were taken during each interview with the respondent's consent.

Secondary data, used mainly in the background and literature review chapters, was obtained from published reports, census data from the National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda, and other credible institutional sources, including the International Growth Centre and Access to Finance Rwanda.

3.5 Data Analysis Methods

Quantitative data collected through the questionnaire was checked for completeness, coded, and entered into statistical software (Microsoft Excel and SPSS) for analysis. Descriptive statistics, including frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations, were used to summarise respondents' demographic characteristics, their level of demand for rental housing, their willingness to pay, and their preferred facilities. Where appropriate, cross-tabulations and a chi-square test of association were used to test the study's hypothesis on the relationship between location/facilities and tenants' willingness to pay, at a 5% level of significance. Results are presented using frequency tables, percentages and charts to make the findings easy to interpret.

Qualitative data obtained from the key informant interviews was analysed using thematic content analysis. Interview notes were read repeatedly, organised into recurring themes related to the study's objectives (such as pricing challenges, tenant turnover and maintenance costs), and summarised narratively to complement and explain the quantitative findings.

3.6 Research Ethics

This study was conducted in accordance with accepted principles of research ethics. Before data collection began, an introductory letter was obtained from the Department of Accounting, Adventist University of Central Africa, authorising the researcher to collect data for academic purposes, and this letter was presented to local authorities at Remera center and to individual respondents where required.

Each respondent was informed of the purpose of the study, and participation was entirely voluntary; a written or verbal consent form was administered before any interview or questionnaire was completed, and respondents were free to withdraw at any stage without any consequence to them. The identity of individual respondents was kept confidential, and information collected was used strictly for academic purposes and reported only in aggregate or anonymised form. Respondents were not exposed to any physical, financial or psychological risk as a result of participating in this study, and no incentive or inducement was offered in exchange for participation, so as to preserve the objectivity of responses given.

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APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: QUESTIONNAIRE FOR POTENTIAL TENANTS

Dear Respondent, this questionnaire is intended purely for academic purposes. It seeks to collect information for a research project on establishing a renting house business at Remera center. All information provided will be treated with strict confidentiality. Thank you for your cooperation.

SECTION A: BACKGROUND INFORMATION

- 1. Sex: Male [ ] Female [ ]
- 2. Age category: 18–25 [ ] 26–35 [ ] 36–45 [ ] Above 45 [ ]
- 3. Occupation: Employee [ ] Business owner/Trader [ ] Student [ ] Other [ ]
- 4. Current place of residence: Within Remera [ ] Outside Remera [ ]

SECTION B: HOUSING SITUATION AND DEMAND

- 5. Do you currently rent a house/room? Yes [ ] No [ ]
- 6. Would you consider renting a house/room at Remera center? Yes [ ] No [ ] Not sure [ ]
- 7. What type of housing unit would you prefer? Single room [ ] Studio [ ] 1-bedroom [ ] 2 or more bedrooms [ ]

SECTION C: WILLINGNESS TO PAY

- 8. How much are you willing to pay per month for your preferred unit? Below 50,000 RWF [ ] 50,000–100,000 RWF [ ] 101,000–150,000 RWF [ ] Above 150,000 RWF [ ]
- 9. Rental price is the most important factor in my choice of house. Strongly disagree [ ] Disagree [ ] Neutral [ ] Agree [ ] Strongly agree [ ]

SECTION D: PREFERRED FACILITIES

- 10. Please rank the importance of the following facilities (1 = Least important, 5 = Most important): Security [ ] Water supply [ ] Electricity [ ] Parking [ ] Proximity to transport [ ]

- 11. Any other comments or suggestions regarding rental housing at Remera center: ____

APPENDIX B: LETTER REQUESTING AUTHORISATION TO CONDUCT RESEARCH

Adventist University of Central Africa

Department of Accounting, Faculty of Business Administration

P.O. Box 82, Kigali, Rwanda

Date: July 2026

To: The Executive Secretary, Remera Sector, Gasabo District

RE: REQUEST FOR AUTHORISATION TO CONDUCT RESEARCH AT REMERA CENTER

Dear Sir/Madam,

I, IYAMUKUZA Aline, Registration Number 20251acc044, am a student pursuing a Bachelor of Arts in Business Administration with Honours in Accounting at the Adventist University of Central Africa. I am undertaking a research project titled "Establishing a Renting House at Remera Center: A Market Survey," submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements of the course of Study and Research Methods.

I kindly request your authorisation to administer questionnaires and conduct brief interviews with residents, traders and landlords within Remera center for the sole purpose of this academic study. I assure you that the information collected will be treated with strict confidentiality and used exclusively for academic purposes.

I look forward to your favourable consideration and support.

Yours faithfully,

IYAMUKUZA Aline Bachelor of Arts in Business Administration, Accounting Adventist University of Central Africa

APPENDIX C: REFERENCE TO THE RESEARCH MANUAL

This research project was prepared with reference to the Adventist University of Central Africa's Research Manual for undergraduate students, particularly the sections outlining the required structure of a research project (cover page, Chapter One to Chapter Three, references and appendices), the referencing style to be used, and the general guidelines on research ethics and field work conduct. Students and examiners are referred to the current edition of the University's Research Manual, obtainable from the Department of Accounting, for the complete and authoritative guidelines governing the format and evaluation of this research project.

APPENDIX D: PARTICIPANT CONSENT FORM

Title of study: Establishing a Renting House at Remera Center: A Market Survey

Researcher: IYAMUKUZA Aline, Adventist University of Central Africa

I confirm that I have been informed about the purpose of this study and that my participation is entirely voluntary. I understand that I may withdraw from the study at any time without giving any reason and without any negative consequence to me. I understand that the information I provide will be kept confidential and used strictly for academic purposes, and that my identity will not be disclosed in the final report.

I hereby consent to participate in this study.

Respondent's Name: ___________________________

Signature: ___________________________

Date: ___________________________

APPENDIX E: SCHEDULE FOR FIELD WORK

Activity	Planned Period (2026)
Development and pre-testing of research instruments	Week 1
Seeking authorisation from Remera Sector authorities	Week 1
Administration of questionnaires to potential tenants	Weeks 2–3
Key informant interviews with landlords/property agents	Week 3
Data cleaning, coding and entry	Week 4
Data analysis and interpretation of results	Week 5
Report writing and submission	Week 6